The process of identification of 'the Kachin' as an identity group appears primarily the result of a clash of different worldviews about the nature of the political community, and of an effective, appropriate, and equitable distribution of power and sociopolitical rights. But is that in fact the case?

## EXPRESSION OF ROOT CAUSE: CLASH OF IDENTITIES OR IDEOLOGIES?

When we asked informants about causes of grievances, all the Kachin civil society and non-state leaders as well as most international observers and some Burman elite referred to deep-seated paternalistic and chauvinistic attitudes by most Burmans towards the 'ethnic' minorities. Most suggested that particularly the Burman military and ex-military ruling elite express these attitudes.

Concerns over Burman paternalism and chauvinism are widespread, and are not new. As a Kachin civil society leader said, "All Burmans are somewhat chauvinistic, and only since [the crackdown on dissent after] '88 have the Burmans begun to see themselves as victims too — which has led to some increase in empathy and feeling of a shared struggle against authoritarianism and an increased recognition of the way minorities have been treated." Another minority civil society leader noted that ordinary Burmans suffered under military rule too, but argued strongly that they never had to face the chauvinistic discrimination felt by the ethnic minorities. There is concern that the Burman majority don't see themselves as an 'ethnic' group; they are 'the Bamar', the rest are 'ethnic minority races', implying a subordinate and dependent status. So in some ways the conflict is not only about ethnic identity, but a ruling elite employing ideas about identity to control political power, both over Burmans but particularly over minorities.

Several Kachin leaders and KIO representatives went further in the interviews, however, arguing for a clash of deep-seated ideologies about sociopolitical organization, claiming a fundamental difference between Kachin and Burman ideals about the proper order of political power and the social contract. This is an interesting narrative, particularly in light of the significant historic role the Communist Party of Burma (CPB) played in the conflicts in the eastern borderlands of Kachin and Shan States.

Quite a few Kachin informants argued at length that the Tatmadaw